

KOO SHUTDOWN

What it means for Made in India social apps

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The founders of Koo, Aprameya Radhakrishna and Mayank Bidawatka,

made the announcement of

shutting down the fledgling microblogging platform on LinkedIn, citing unsuccessful attempts to secure funding and partnerships for continued growth.

After its launch in 2020, Koo gained initial momentum in 2021 during a period of tension between the Indian government and Twitter. The platform attracted government officials and celebrities, promoting itself as a space for discussions in Indian languages. At its peak, Koo grossed over 2.1 million daily active users, about 10 million monthly active users, and over 9,000 high profile personalities from various fields were active on the homegrown Twitter alternative. What's more, Koo even expanded to markets like Nigeria and Brazil, where it managed to get some traction, as unbelievable as it sounds. According to its co-founders, Koo was just "months away from beating Twitter in India" in 2022, poised to double down on its growth spurt with timely capital infusion. But it wasn't to be.

However, despite its semblance of growth, Koo struggled to secure long-term funding. Negotiations with potential

go as one of its key differentiators (compared to Twitter), offering support for multiple regional tongues – while Twitter, as you all very well know, largely caters to an English speaking audience. This linguistic diversity made Koo more inclusive and palatable for India's diverse population. Additionally, Koo's character limit was also higher than Twitter's – 500 characters vs 280 characters – allowing for longer posts and more wholesome conversations.

While Twitter boasted off a global user base and established brand recognition, Koo was positioning itself as a much-needed homegrown alternative to cater to the Indian audience's unique taste. This localisation and language focus should have given Koo a competitive edge in the Indian market, especially among users seeking a platform that resonates with their cultural and linguistic identity. Unfortunately, that didn't come to pass.



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hile we were busy doom scrolling through the latest Insta Reels and YouTube Shorts,

laughing at viral videos and sniggering at the latest memes, how many of us even realised that one of India's own homegrown social media platforms quietly went into the sunset? Unfortunately, Koo has announced it will be shutting down operations, thereby bringing down the curtains on a homegrown social media platform that promised a lot but ultimately failed to deliver on its early hype.

Launched in 2020, at the height of the pandemic, Koo was positioned as an Indian alternative to Twitter (now X.com). Koo and Twitter shared a fundamental similarity as microblogging platforms, wherein they both allowed users to share short text posts. Both offered features like following, liking, retweeting (or re-kooing, in the case of Koo), and direct messaging between users. Both platforms also hosted trending topics and allowed users to share media like images and videos, among other things.

However, compared to Twitter (X.com) there were some key differences that set Koo apart. Since it was a made in India social media platform for a predominantly Indian audience, Koo had a strong focus on Indian languages from the get